

Touch and motion

Animals use their sense of touch to feel their surroundings. If something new touches them, or moves nearby, they react right away. Animals use touch to protect themselves, to communicate, and also to find food. In addition to touch, animals have an internal sense that detects gravity and motion, telling them which way up they are.

Touchy feeders

Giant anteaters have very poor eyesight and track down their food by smell. Once they have found an ant or termite nest, they use touch to help gather up their food. A giant anteater's tongue can be up to 20 in (50 cm) long, and its sensitive tip probes deep inside a nest's narrow galleries. Using a large amount of sticky saliva that works like glue, the tongue flicks in and out like a high-speed pump, collecting up to 25,000 insects a day.



Toothless jaws form a tubular snout

Powerful claw, which folds back when walking, rips open an insect nest

Long, narrow tongue

Statocyst located near base of first pair of antennae



Feelings inside

Animals need to be able to tell up from down. A crab does this with its eyes and, like most invertebrates, also with internal sensors called statocysts. A statocyst is a hollow chamber containing a heavy mineral grain. Gravity pulls the grain, triggering the statocyst. This tells the crab which way is up and whether it is speeding up or slowing down. Vertebrates have similar sense organs in their inner ear.

